

PAOLA UGALDE ARAYA

CONTACT INFORMATION

Department of Economics
Louisiana State University
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EMPLOYMENT

Assistant Professor, Department of Economics, Louisiana State University, 2023-

EDUCATION

Ph.D. Economics, Arizona State University (2023)
M.S. Economics, Arizona State University (2021)
M.A. Economic Theory, ITAM (2017)
B.A. Economics, University of Costa Rica (2013)

RESEARCH FIELDS

Applied Microeconomics, Labor Economics, Economics of Education, Gender Economics

RESEARCH

Published Papers

“Gendered Effects of Labels on Advanced Course Enrollment” *Journal of Economic Behavior & Organization*, 2025
“A (Dynamic) Investigation of Stereotypes, Belief-Updating, and Behavior” with Katherine Coffman and Basit Zafar, *Economic Inquiry*, 2024
“The Impact of COVID-19 on Student Experiences and Expectations: Evidence from a Survey” with Esteban Aucejo, Jacob French, and Basit Zafar, *Journal of Public Economics*, 2020

Working Papers

“Political Views & College Choices in a Polarized America” with Riley Acton and Emily Cook
“Gender Differences in Preferences for Grades and Major Choice” (*Revise and Resubmit JHR*)
“Same Degree, Different Education: The Transition to a 12-Year Curriculum in Louisiana” with Scott Abrahams (*Reject and Resubmit JHR*)
“Understanding Gaps in College Outcomes by First-Generation Status” with Esteban Aucejo, Jacob French, and Basit Zafar (*Submitted*)
“The Role of Teacher Private Information in Predicting Student Test Scores” with Esteban Aucejo and Ilkem Gok Karci. (*Submitted*)

Research in Progress

“Gender Gap in Performance When Shaken and Stressed: Evidence from Korea’s College Scholastic Ability Test During Earthquakes” with Eunju Lee

COMPUTATIONAL SKILLS

Programming: Stata, Python, SQL, MATLAB
Survey Tools: Qualtrics, oTree (platform for web-based experiments)

ACADEMIC PRESENTATIONS

2026 AEFPP Annual Conference, NBER Education Program Spring Meeting, Society of Labor Economists Annual Meeting
2025: MidSouth Education Policy Workshop, Costa Rican Conference of Economists
2024: University of Costa Rica
2023: Louisiana State University, Rochester Institute of Technology, Tecnológico de Monterrey, Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting, Ohio State University
2022: Ph.D. Reunion Conference, Arizona State University
2020: Workshop on Subjective Expectations

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Principles of Microeconomics (ECON 2000), LSU: Spring 2024 - 2026
Intermediate Microeconomic Theory (ECON 4720), LSU: Fall 2023- Spring 2026
Microeconomics Principles (ECN 212), ASU: Summer 2020 and 2021
Principles of Economics (XE0156), UCR: Spring/Fall 2014, Spring 2015

GRANTS

Spencer Foundation Research Grant on Education (Co-PI with Emily Cook & Riley Acton), \$50,000, 2025–2027
LSU Provost's Fund for Innovation in Research Grant, \$10,000, 2024
Spring 2026 Faculty Travel Award, Provost's Fund for Innovation in Research, 2026
Graduate Research and Support Program Grant, 2020–2021

AWARDS & HONORS

Summer Scholar, Postsecondary Education & Economics Research Center (PEER), 2026
Dal and Leslie Miller Excellence in Teaching Award 2025-2026
Best Written Comprehensive Exam (Third-year paper) 2020
Graduation with Honors, B.A. Economics 2014
Best Student, Economics Department 2010 & 2013
Academic Excellence Scholarship, B.A. Economics 2010-2013

REFeree

Quarterly Journal of Economics, Journal of Labor Economics, Journal of Human Resources, Education Economics, Economic Modeling, Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization, Higher Education, Empirical Economics, International Review of Economics, Management Science, Economic Bulletin, Economic Journal, European Economic Review.

LANGUAGES

English (fluent)
Spanish (native)